

NiemanLab

THE WEEKLY WRAP: OCTOBER 10, 2025

Publishers say generative AI is cutting into their traffic. New research shows just why they're right

People are turning to generative AI for different reasons than they did a year ago, according to [new research](#) from the Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism (RISJ) that surveyed users across six countries.

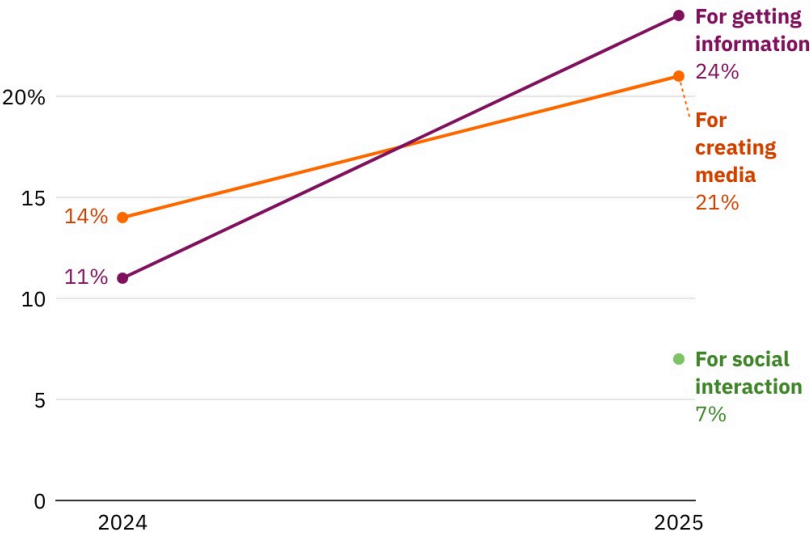
"Last year, creating media — for example, creating an image or a summary — was the top use case," RISJ fellow Felix M. Simon [wrote for us](#) this week. "This year, information-seeking has taken the lead, more than doubling from 11% to 24% weekly."

People now use AI to "research topics, answer factual questions, and ask for advice. They are, in essence, increasingly using it for tasks that were once the primary domain of search engines and, by extension, news publishers."

The shift away from creation and toward information-seeking has direct implications for publishers who rely on search traffic, and they [notice the decline](#). More worrying than the "10 to 15% decline that we see coming from search referrals globally," Matthew Monahan, president of The Washington Post's Arc XP CMS for media companies, [said at a Press Gazette conference](#) this week, there's a "drop in direct traffic from young audiences."

Proportion that used generative AI for each in the last week

Using generative AI for getting information has overtaken using it for creating media (text, images, video, etc.).

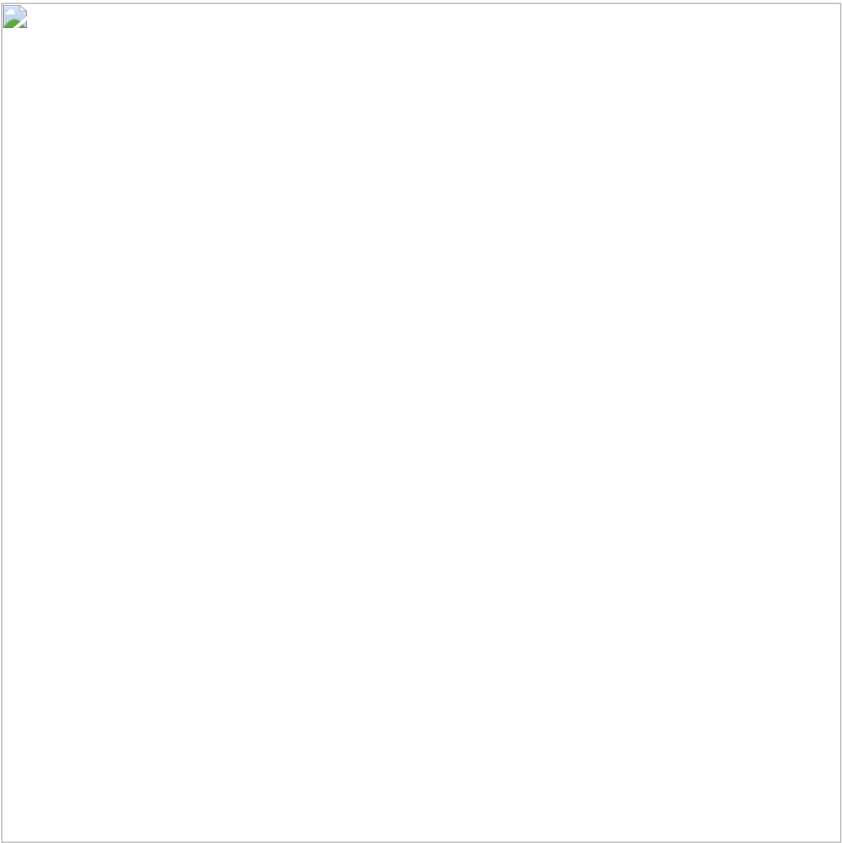


AI_outputs. Which, if any, of the following have you tried to use it for in the last week (even if it didn't work)? *Base: Total sample across Argentina, Denmark, France, Japan, the UK, the USA in each year ≈ 12,000.*

Source: Generative AI and news report 2025: How people think about AI's role in journalism and society



Here in the U.S., 61% of respondents said they'd seen an AI-generated answer in search in the last week; 64% of respondents in the U.K. and 70% in Argentina said the same. (The numbers in France are lower because Google [hasn't rolled out](#) AI Overviews, [its AI-generated search summaries](#), there yet.)



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"For publishers worried about declining referral traffic, our findings paint a worrying picture, in line with other recent findings in industry and academic research," Simon writes. "Among those who say they have seen AI answers for their searches, only a third say they 'always or often' click through to the source links, while 28% say they 'rarely or never' do. This suggests a significant portion of user journeys may now end on the search results page."

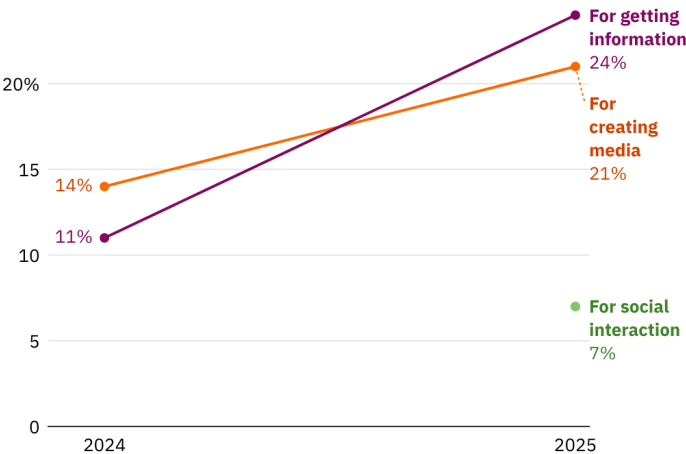
— Laura Hazard Owen



Re:Public is reporting stories about the lands that belong to all of us

The new publication, from former Outside Magazine EIC Chris Keyes, will focus on longform stories about the 660 million acres of public lands and waters in the U.S. *By Neel Dhanesha.*

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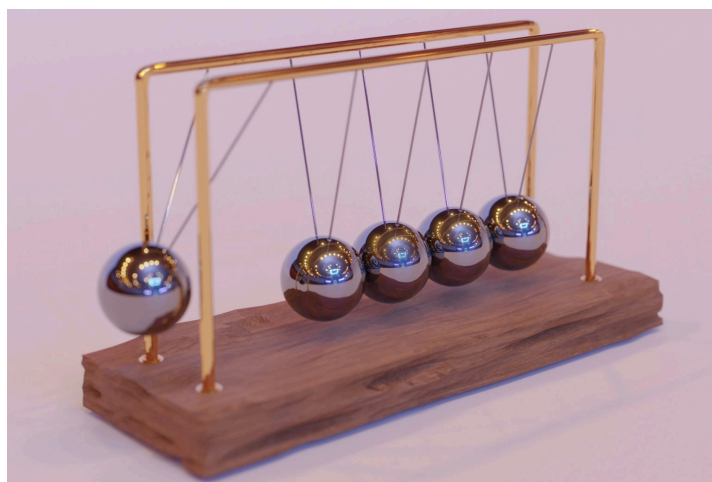
People are using ChatGPT twice as much as they were last year. They're still just as skeptical of AI in news.

"For news organizations, our findings are in some ways bitter medicine." *By Felix M. Simon.*



Watchdog journalism's future may lie in the work of independent reporters like Pablo Torre

With past journalistic stints at both Sports Illustrated and ESPN, Torre is not exactly a pure outsider. Yet he's far from a household name, with fewer than 200,000 podcast subscribers. *By Alex Volonte.*



"Impact editor" is a relatively new job, and it's already changing

Newsrooms can try to define impact even at the beginning of the reporting process, impact editors say. *By Hanaa' Tameez.*



Bari Weiss's CBS News and MSNBC both just laid out their new journalistic

principles — and they're fascinatingly different

CBS: "America," "American," "all of the tools of the digital era," and speed. MSNBC: Press freedom, the First Amendment, and ethics. *By Laura Hazard Owen.*

Nonprofit news is growing strong — especially local nonprofit news, a new report shows

ChatGPT, not satisfied with being an app, wants to become your life's operating system

WHAT WE'RE READING

INDISTINCT CHATTER / JENNIFER SCHULZE

Local journalists and residents tell Chicago's story as ICE moves in →

"Some of the most shocking examples of ICE gone wild have come from Chicago residents who grabbed their phone and hit record just like Illinois Governor J.B. Pritzker has been suggesting...the national media needs to step up its coverage of what's happening here in Chicago. There has been some solid coverage but not nearly enough. This is 'lead story, headline news, continuous coverage, send your reporters and lead anchors here to report on what's happening' time."

THE NEW YORK TIMES / KATIE ROBERTSON

Los Angeles Times moves closer to a public stock offering →

"The company announced a so-called private placement seeking to raise up to \$500 million for the newly created Los Angeles Times Media Group, which includes the newspaper as well as LA Times Studios and two of [owner Patrick Soon-Shiong]'s other businesses: the virtual production company NantStudios and the gaming and esports studio NantGames."

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER / KATIE KILKENNY

Los Angeles Times journalists authorize a strike →

"The move only gives the union the ability to call a strike; it does not guarantee that one will take place, and no date has been set. But it's a significant effort on the part of the union to apply pressure to management after an unusually long [three-year] contract negotiations period."

NIEMAN REPORTS / VIDYA KRISHNAN

India is relying on lawfare to stifle the press →

"Over recent years there is an increasing brazenness by the government and corporations to bend the law and regulatory frameworks in our country to direct censorship."

MEDIAITE / COLBY HALL

Mark Thompson insists the forthcoming CNN streaming service will be a "comprehensive news service" for cordcutters →

"If you cut the cord, you miss news. This will be a way of getting news back in a way you can watch on a connected TV or your phone or pretty much every other digital device."

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"I think there's this old idea that you need to be assigned a story, or given permission to pursue something, when in reality all you need is to be a nosy bitch with a smartphone." →

—Independent journalist Marisa Kabas in a speech to Grinnell College students on October 8 (The Handbasket / Marisa Kabas)

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CJR / IVAN L. NAGY

The editor-in-chief of Rest of World was on vacation in his home country of Nepal. Then a revolution unfolded. →

"People saw the media as being on their side for a long time. Nepal has gone through a number of revolutions, and the media was seen as one of the political powers that helped fight against autocracy and helped usher the country toward democracy. But in the last decade or so, there's been disenchantment. Even though there are thousands of online media outlets, they haven't really evolved in terms of what they cover, how they cover it, and are they really doing a public service? I think that's been the perception."

THE WASHINGTON POST / CAITLIN GILBERT, RICHARD SIMA, LESLIE SHAPIRO, AARON STECKELBERG, AND CLARA ENCE MORSE

A giant Washington Post investigation shows how TikTok keeps its users scrolling for hours a day →

"The Washington Post, through an unprecedented partnership with our readers, collected TikTok watch histories from 1,100 users. We created a database of roughly 15 million videos served up to them in a six-month period last year. Our analyses showed just how effective TikTok is at

Publishers say generative AI is cutting into their traffic. New research shows just why they're right getting even its heaviest users to swipe more and watch more on its platform."

THE VERGE / ELIZABETH LOPATTO

Memo to Bari Weiss: You're doomed →

"On a business level, your problem with TikTok is this: Platforms exist to erode institutions like CBS News. You cannot solve your problems with improved distribution on TikTok. The things that work on television for 60-year-olds do not work on TikTok for 14-year-olds, first of all. But more importantly, TikTokers monetize their channels by directly integrating advertising and brands into their content, a strategy in immediate conflict with the values and ethics of a storied news organization like CBS News. Even if you somehow manage to crack TikTok's algorithm, you still won't make enough revenue to survive without trashing the very soul of the institution you're purporting to save."

THE GUARDIAN / KIRAN STACEY AND MICHAEL SAVAGE

BBC bosses want to use the U.K.'s military to help pay for the World Service →

"Senior executives at the corporation are in talks with officials over whether parts of the service, such as media monitoring and anti-disinformation, should count towards Britain's security, as they attempt to avoid cuts of tens of millions of pounds."

MEDIAPOST / RAY SCHULTZ

Lee newspapers are killing their Monday print editions →

"The change to our Monday publication will help us focus our resources and time on the products readers are using the most." Among those effected: the St. Louis Post-Dispatch, the Omaha World-Herald, the Buffalo News, and the Richmond Times-Dispatch.

AXIOS / JOSEPHINE WALKER

Chicago journalists sue Trump over "extreme brutality" at ICE protests →

"They allege that officers, dressed in 'full combat gear, often masked, carrying weapons, bearing flash grenades and tear gas canisters...have repeatedly advanced upon those present at the scene who posed no imminent threat to law enforcement.' The plaintiffs are a coalition of Chicago news associations and labor unions, along with the nonprofit newsroom Block Club Chicago."

POYNTER / TOM JONES

Rick Edmonds, Poynter’s media business analyst, dies at the age of 78 →

“Poynter president Neil Brown wrote in a note to staff, ‘Be it the economics or the ethics of the news business, Rick’s writing was accessible and his sources were deep. His approach to his work and to his colleagues was gracious and joyful.’”

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